

THE TROLLEY PROBLEM

The trolley problem is a set of imaginary cases designed to test how we decide what is right. In each one a runaway tram threatens to kill five people, and in each one you could save them, but only at the cost of a single life. The cases look almost identical, yet most people answer them very differently.

Key Terms

Consequences: the results an action brings about. On one view, the results are the only thing that matters morally.

Intuition: a strong sense that something is right or wrong, felt before you have worked out the reasons.

Using someone as a means: treating a person merely as a tool to bring about some other end.

1. THE SWITCH

Philippa Foot (1967).

A runaway tram is hurtling down the track. Ahead of it, five people are trapped on the line and cannot get away; the tram will certainly kill them. You are standing beside a lever. If you pull it, the tram will turn onto a side track, where it will kill one person instead. There is no other way to stop it. Do you pull the lever?

2. THE FOOTBRIDGE

Judith Jarvis Thomson (1976).

The same runaway tram is about to kill five people. This time you are standing on a footbridge above the track, next to a large stranger. The only way to stop the tram is to push him off the bridge into its path: his body would bring the tram to a halt and save the five, but he would die. You are not heavy enough to stop it yourself. Do you push him?

3. THE LOOP

Judith Jarvis Thomson (1985).

Once again the tram is heading for the five, and once again you can turn it aside with a lever. But this time the side track loops back round to the main line, so the tram would eventually return and kill the five anyway, except that there is one large person on the loop whose body will stop it. Here the one person's

death is not an accidental side effect of saving the five; it is the very thing that saves them. Do you pull the lever?

4. THE TRANSPLANT

Adapted from Philippa Foot and Judith Jarvis Thomson.

A surgeon has five patients who will each die soon without a transplant: one needs a heart, another a liver, others a pair of kidneys, and so on. A healthy young visitor arrives for a routine check-up. The surgeon realises that this one person's organs could save all five patients, and that no one would ever know. Should the surgeon kill the visitor to save the five?

THE PUZZLE

Most people say yes to the Switch but no to the Footbridge and the Transplant, even though in every case one life is traded for five. One way of thinking counts only the outcome: five deaths are worse than one, so saving the greater number is always right. Another way holds that certain actions, such as using a person's body as a tool or deliberately killing the innocent, are wrong in themselves, whatever the numbers. The trolley problem is built to make these two ways of thinking collide.

PART C: CLASS DISCUSSION

Why does pulling the lever feel different from pushing the stranger off the bridge, when both trade one life for five? Is there a real moral difference between them, or only a difference in how they feel?